After a hot day I yearn for a cold beer and silently curse the powers that have made Gujarat a dry state. For those in the know, a guide told me, prohibition is a joke; country liquor is available in every village. Mafias in Ahmedabad deliver liquor at home like pizza. The Harappans, going by a distiller excavated at a site in Sindh, were perhaps the first people in the world to distil alcoholic beverages.[34] A Harappan artefact is said to 'represent the press used to make soma, a hallucinogenic drink known from later Vedic texts' composed in the subcontinent.[35] As I sit thirsting for a beer, it seems to me that in at least one way, Gujarati politicians have regressed to the Stone Age.

The Decline of the Harappan Civilization

The mature Harappan age lasted an impressive 700 years (longer in some parts, including Gujarat). No one is sure why their industrial production and long-distance trade declined and their cities began depopulating after 1900 BCE, or why their script went out of use after 1800 BCE. There is no evidence yet of war, invasion or an epidemic. It appears to have been a slow, uneven process of urban collapse, desertion and dispersal, until its last vestiges vanished everywhere by 1300 BCE. How did archaeologists detect this civilizational decline? Robinson explains:

> In the most recent levels of Harappa and Mohenjo-daro the early excavators found distinct signs of deterioration in the conditions of houses, drainage and urban existence. At Mohenjo-daro, huts were poorly constructed out of used and often broken bricks; kilns were built in the middle of streets; and some bodies were left unburied . . . Moreover, painted pottery largely gave way to plain wares and inscribed seals were no longer in use.

Similar signs of decline occurred at Dholavira too. Across the realm, the decline, however, had regional variants, was non-linear, and even had halting, temporary revivals, often led by different cultural groups dubbed 'post-Harappans'. After its final demise, it took nearly a millennium for the next cities to arise in the subcontinent—in faraway Gangetic Plain— with no apparent awareness of their Harappan predecessors. Oddly, the